

THEY KNOW EVERYTHING ABOUT YOU!

But who are “they” and what exactly do they “know”? Let’s find out...

Robert Sovereign-Smith | editor@digit.in

First off, my apologies for the clickbait headline. I hate using them, but sometimes there’s really no option, because the topic itself is what I consider to be clickbait. Next, I want to explain that I’m writing this in the first person, because I’m going to be sharing my own personal data here as a way of illustrating what “they” know about me specifically, as a way of showing you what they know about you. And while I’m throwing out explanations, I should also add that none of this surprised me at all, but it seems like a lot of people across the world are suddenly waking up to reality – a little too late, I might add.

NOT JUST FACEBOOK

Now I know everyone (hopefully) already knows this, but we tend to forget with all the hype around Facebook, the Congressional hearings, headlines from around the globe, etc. Thus, it’s a good starting point to this article. When I say “they” in the headline, it’s far more than Facebook, or social me-

dia companies, or even tech companies in general.

In the age of big data, “they” is just about anyone... anyone I email, anyone I give a business card to, any app I use, website I sign in to, any service I use... offline or online... just about anything I do. Thanks to Aadhaar, a driving license, passport, mobile phone, bank account, email, etc, all of us are going to exist as data somewhere. This isn’t new, and it isn’t news, and we’ve come to increasingly accept such agencies gathering data about us.

What seems to be upsetting a rather large group of people, suddenly, is the realisation that this data is being weaponised by marketers against us. Whether it’s to entice us to buy something new, or to entice us to vote a certain way, a lot of people don’t like being reminded that all of us humans are actually gullible.

NOT NEW

Another thing we all tend to forget is that none of this is new. Civilisation itself is based on people with ideas try-

ing to sway your opinions, and we’ve done it successfully for far longer than we can go back in known history! If it’s not whom to fight for, it’s whom to vote for, or whom to buy from, and that basic human tendency is not something we’re going to escape. Ever. It’s certainly not something that’s been invented with the internet, or with Google or Facebook. If anything, it’s only misused because we’re always a lazy bunch, and always will be. Let me explain that.

Even decades ago, when politicians (or their representatives) would come around door-to-door, campaigning to our grandparents, do we really think most of them went about trying to hear from all of the candidates in the fray? If the politician didn’t have the time or the money to show up, or pay someone to show up on his/her stead, our grandparents would just not hear from them, and probably never vote for them. Today, it’s a person or a company with money that will throw ads in your face everywhere and try and sway your opinion in that way. Social